

Dualism

in Our Most Recent Philosophy

G. Brandes

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Translated from the Danish by Hans Halvorson

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1. Introduction.

There is something in Prof. R. Nielsen's account of the relation between science and [7] biblical faith that is bound to win him many hearts. One feels a reassurance joined to satisfaction, a glad confirmation of something one had wished for, perhaps without much hope, on hearing a thinker speak so severely of the impotence of human thought, on seeing so great and comprehensive a philosophical talent so conscious of philosophy's limits. One came to the philosopher all too accustomed to the phrase, repeated to the point of triviality, that the educated man — sometimes with pride, sometimes with pain — feels himself torn loose from the presuppositions on which the unlearned and simple build with confidence; and one goes away strengthened in one's trust that it is only superficial and immature philosophy that leads away from biblical faith, and not the true, deep, real understanding of what can be understood. And admiration mixes itself into the satisfaction. This is the same man who with so much zeal and warmth has upheld the independence of the special sciences against the pretensions of an arrogant [8] speculation; who, standing at the high point of his age's scientific culture, girded with the strength-belt of his genius and his cultivation, has moderation, sobriety, humility and piety enough to declare that life is more than contemplation, character more than intelligence, practice more than theory, and religion higher than science. Other thinkers, lesser thinkers, foreign philosophers and German ones above all, have let themselves be lured into the ill-famed modern freethinking; they have given offence by attacking what the tradition of centuries has stamped as holy. Our own philosophy, under this thinker's auspices, will run in a better track: without renouncing the freedom that is thought's right and its condition of life, it will preserve reverence for the holy in a dignified self-command, clean of the excesses to which science has given itself over everywhere else in Europe and in part here in Denmark too. Who has not had enough of barren polemics, of the appetite for demolition and the rage for annihilation? What is finer and better than this so sincerely and vigorously declared effort to make peace at last between powers that, each of infinite importance in itself, ought to be working peaceably together toward a common goal!

In these or similar terms admiration will clothe itself, and the circle that talks this way is hardly a small one. For this philosophy is in more than one respect a philosophy [9] of reconciliation. It reconciles not only principles but parties; it looks for its friends in opposite camps. Though in religious matters its whole content of ideas comes from Kierkegaard, it is nonetheless raised above what it must regard as a limitation in that great genius. It sees not merely, as nearly everyone does, what is in many ways stirring and good in the life that has issued from Grundtvig and his followers; it has an eye for the deep truth in Grundtvig's discovery, the standpoint for which Kierkegaard, and so many with him, are unable to find. For this philosophy knows how to value fresh immediacy as well as fully carried-through reflection. It is hostile only to the sphere in between, only to the murky commingling of the scientific and the religious — in one word, to theology. And yet it is convinced that the theologians, once they get a proper view of what is in the highest sense their own interest, will feel the need to gather under its broad wings together with their former opponents; for what the best among these want, it wants too: the holiness of the uncut, inviolable word of the Bible, and faith's independence of an ever more demanding and inconsiderate modern science. Finally, it does not shut itself up with its initiates in a sealed room. It is intent on gaining currency among the generally educated, and indeed among the great teachable mass of the people, whom it is a pleasure to instruct for anyone lucky enough to have the gift for it. It is as [10] popular when it turns outward as it is strict and exact in its dealings within; as soft and conciliatory when the business is to unite whatever is great and distinguished that our fatherland has brought forth in godly and churchly matters^{*)}, as it is firm of character and inexorable toward theology's attempts at mediation (which are a matter of indifference to the general public).

How much there is in such a programme that appeals to what is best in a man, and that would at any time make an impression on every mature and developed mind — and how much there is in it, finally, that must strike precisely the people of our time and our country!

The nineteenth century turned early against the philosophy of the eighteenth; but here in Denmark perhaps more decidedly, and at all events more persistently, than anywhere else. However fiercely our theologians have warred with one another, Danish literature bears neither many nor strong traces of the critical movement that characterises German and French science in the present century. The age of the rebirth of religious movements has nothing to spare for rationalism. It abhors the flatness of the

^{*)}See e.g. Nord. Universitetstidsskr., supplementary number to vol. 10, 1866, p. 75.

old rationalism; it strongly doubts that any good can come of unsettling the authority of positive religion once more; it is reluctant to see any of revelation's outworks given up, for it feels the necessity of *principiis obstare*. This turn of mind Prof. Nielsen comes out [11] to meet. He secures the outermost entrenchment of the positive by setting a yawning abyss between science and religion, and throwing the theologians headlong into it.

But the nineteenth century is also the age of natural science and of the great discoveries. If it is clear about anything, it is that in the domain of science we must have the field free, we must be able to investigate and determine unchallenged by the preconceived and narrow judgments of an outdated orthodoxy. This consciousness too Prof. Nielsen comes out to meet. When the talk is of science, then the talk is not of faith; then the Professor stands — or at any rate means to stand — free and unhindered by any binding prejudice whatever, and no freethinker, however impatient, has been able to speak more vehemently on the point than he.

What more can one want, what can one still wish for beyond this magnificent execution of *suum cuique*! Who will raise an objection here — unless perhaps the straggler who has not yet grasped that the age of dogmatics is over, or the narrow-minded man who cannot bear that the great public should be given a share in philosophy's results, or the individual who comes forward not for the sake of the cause but to push his own little self into the foreground with the help of the great cause^{*)}?

Let us turn the medal over for once and look at the other side. This doctrine, which [12] appeals to so much that is good in people and shows itself so much in tune with the times — might it not also be addressing itself to something less good, to what is lower in us, indeed to the lowest? We human beings are by nature inclined to slackness, to dividedness, to dissipation. Most people are happy to have one view of life in joy and another in sorrow, one at home and another in church. The teacher prefers to profess one principle when he speaks and another when he acts; the priest has trouble living as he preaches; the merchant generally has one morality in business and another in life; and the poet sings again and again of ideals that are least of all to be met with in his [13]

^{*)}Cf. R. Schmidt: Om Selvmødsigelsen i Prof. Nielsens Lære, p. 44.

Just as Mr. Schmidt supposes that something morally incriminating must lie behind the act of standing up against Prof. Nielsen, so Mr. Henrik Scharling cannot conceive that one might speak against theology on any but personal grounds. He declares that I appear to be of the opinion that if theology cannot make me a Christian, then it is barren and impractical; and he adds instructively that one can of course no more become a Christian merely by studying theology than one can recover one's health merely by studying medicine. Although Mr. Scharling's drollery as literature's mentor is not unknown, and although one must no doubt be prepared to meet a certain familiarity with omniscience in a theological weekly, this outburst of Mr. Scharling's was nevertheless a welcome surprise to me. It is so agreeable to find in a journal information about one's own spiritual history — and information, at that, of which one was previously quite unaware.

own conduct. The one sphere, after all, is no concern of the other; the one hand need not know what the other is doing. And now the man of science! Brought up in some definite church faith, influenced from childhood by some definite accidental circle of representations — the one that prevails in his church, in his country and in the town where he lives — he encounters in science facts that conflict with this faith. Here is a battle to be fought out, a victory to be won. But could peace not be had more cheaply? Appalling thought, that the faith preached in Ebeltoft or in Paris or in St. Petersburg should not be the highest truth! Appalling faithlessness, to break with a faith in which one's Ebeltoft or Parisian or St. Petersburg parents placed all their trust! What is more natural, then, than the practical expedient of being one man in science and another in one's life — of living one's whole life through in a chaotic world view with fragments of the past's outlook and scraps of the present's, while appearing in one's writings dressed in the scientific drapery of the nineteenth century.

Yet however naturally this comes, there is something painful in such halfness. One is reluctant, no doubt, to gather oneself for the forceful, single decision; but neither does one care to waver without principle between opposed points of view. No compromise! — that is the watchword nowadays; far rather a sturdy disharmony! Halved one will be, if [14] it cannot be otherwise, but then one will be halved thoroughly. What a relief, then, for the hard-pressed soul is the new doctrine, which does grant science its right, if under compulsion, but all the same leaves me my childhood faith — and my nursery learning too, if it comes to that — in good order; which in short raises unprincipledness itself into a principle, and gives the uncertain man precisely what he craves: leave to be whole in his halfness, to breathe fully as a double human being. His understanding needs air, and it is given free play, a field to range in without limits; while his feeling, which is at odds with his understanding, and his will, which in its need of outward support parts only with difficulty from any article of faith handed down from the fathers, need give up nothing at all. Faith is justified the moment it is merely firm; its kingdom is without barriers, its territory has no boundary in common with the land of cognition. Each of the two realms has its own laws, its own ruler, indeed its own God; they cannot fall out with one another over what is true, for this very discord between them is the truth, is the peace. As when two great powers stand fully armed against one another, but mediation intervenes, no war breaks out, and a settlement is struck in which each party, fully armed, reserves all its rights — so here the debate is stifled under a storm-laden pause: neither of the two opponents gives up a jot. Regarded as a temporary situation, or [15] as a truce after old battles, this standstill may have its use; it is even of value to science,

if science is really allowed to live its own life undisturbed by outside interference. But if it is to be taken for a settlement of the dispute, for the long-awaited solution of a great problem — and this is what it is given out to be^{*)} — then its weakness is so glaring that it would be a disgrace to our science if it were not pointed out.

We have seen what might tempt even the man of science to attach himself to the new doctrine and to realise it for his own part. But if the temptation can become too strong even for him, how much greater must it be for the layman. Suppose he has from childhood a need for unconditional surrender and heartfelt faith. Suppose, next, that while his heart seeks positive religion, his reason is at the same time repelled by many a crudity that seems inseparably bound up with religion. If he now rejects religion unconditionally, his heart languishes forever in its want; if instead he accepts it without reservation in its handed-down shape, it is as though an iron band were clapped about his brow. So he sits fast in the dilemma of choice. Suppose, then, that one evening he steps into a lecture hall where listeners of both sexes, educated and uneducated, have crowded together. The lecture he happens to hear is aimed at speculative theology. With all the assurance that learning, logical virtuosity and lively eloquence confer, the speaker sets out how dangerous it is, in matters of faith, to give science so much as one's [16] little finger. On science's behalf he enters a protest against the credibility of the biblical miracles. He presents first, perhaps — always from science's standpoint, of course — the improbability, the absurdity of some of the miracles that have little nimbus for his hearers' imagination but are all the more an offence to their understanding. The listening circle is not disquieted yet; it feels rather a relief of mind at letting its pent-up indignation run free for once. But the speaker goes further. He approaches, perhaps, miracles that stand to everyone as holy mysteries; for a moment it looks as though he meant to lay hands on them, and a tremor passes through the assembly. The consequence of the theologians' attempts at explanation has now been made plain. Then the speaker turns the hourglass of his lecture. With warm enthusiasm, with still greater eloquence, he presents the miracle seen in the light of faith. And now, when the critical inclination has been allowed to spend its rage, now that one has learned to shudder at the train of thought one was lately willing to enter upon, one embraces with the same passion great and small, the most exalted religious commandment and the most trifling miracle; everything seems equally holy and precious now that the danger of losing it is hardly past. What has the hearer not felt and lived through in such an hour, how freely have all his faculties ranged! Reason and the craving for faith are equally satisfied — the one [17]

^{*)}See e.g. "Fædrelandet" 1866 no. 172.

because it has been given leave to throw the whole flock of miracles out of science's front gate, the other because it has been given complete freedom to let that same throng in at the back gate that stands open to it in the individual's practical existence. Forward and back seem equally far; but the hearer has exercised his spiritual powers, and he has learned once and for all how he is to handle his understanding every time its impatience threatens to expose him afresh to the temptations of offence. In his joy it escapes him that what has been carried out here is only a feigned manoeuvre; that since the concept of God and the concept of the world which Prof. N. sets against theology's are, on the Professor's own view, not the true ones, not the ones that have reality, the battle fought here against speculative theology is only a sham battle — a mock skirmish, as Holberg calls it — and that all that has happened is a restationing of the suprarational from the domain of science to the domain of life: a tactical change, analogous to the one that would have taken place in chemistry if the chemists had at some point agreed to tolerate phlogiston no longer in their science, but only so as to be all the more fervently convinced of its existence outside science.

Or perhaps the groping, unsettled man turns to literature, and stops one fine day at [18] the reading of a page like this^{*)}, containing the close of a conversation in which theology's defender comes off pitifully. The theologian C. has put forward the proposition that in the objective sense everything, or else nothing, is to be called a miracle. To this A. replies as follows:

“That a man walks on the sea without sinking — is that then just as much in accord with the immutability of the laws of nature as that someone falls into the water and drowns? C. The human being, who is otherwise subject to the laws of gravity, may very well walk on the sea when it happens *teleologically*, in virtue of a continued creation! A. But then, so far as the immutability of the laws of nature is concerned, there is presumably nothing offensive to deeper thinking either, if we consider it properly, in a pope, Leo XII, having been able to beatify the Minorite Julianus, who in our unbelieving, revolutionary nineteenth century made roasted birds fly? C. That I for my part take the miracle of the roasted birds to be a stupid fable, a priest's lie, comes not at all from my seeing in the event itself any breach of the immutability of the laws of nature, but simply from my not being a Catholic and consequently not being able to convince myself that the event happened teleologically, in virtue of a continued creation. Were I a Catholic and had a Catholic's faith, I should no doubt be capable of reconciling my faith with my knowledge, my concept of creation with my concept of nature . . .”

^{*)}R. Nielsen: Forelæsninger over Philosoph. Propædeutik. Efteraarshalvaar 1865 p. 159.

What has happened here? In making theology's attempts at explanation ridiculous, in showing the supposed understanding of the miracle to be merely supposed, the mockery [19] strikes speculative dogmatics not only as that which — in principle — is capable of comprehending so insane a miracle, but as that which is not in a position to turn it away. And so a ridiculous light falls over the miraculous world itself with which dogmatics deals: the world, namely, in which roasted birds can be made to fly. Here again the sympathetic reader feels his understanding satisfied. Although no miracle venerable by its age has been brought even under the shadow of a critique by the understanding, he takes comfort all the same in the thought that he at least is not obliged to resort to arguments like C.'s in order to fend off miracles of the sort of the one with the birds. But this feeling rests on pure illusion. For take up the thread of the conversation and turn the reply against Mr. A., and it will appear that his arguments are not a hair better than his humiliated opponent's, and that his position is quite as peculiar as Mr. C.'s. Ask him, with only a few words altered: Is there then, so far as the immutability of the laws of nature is concerned, anything offensive to *your* innermost consciousness in a man of our century having made roasted birds fly? Then the answer would have to run something like this: That I for my part take the miracle to be a stupid fable, a priest's lie, comes not at all from my seeing in the event a breach of the immutability of the laws of nature — for even if it does contain one, I dare not deny its possibility — but simply from my not [20] being a Catholic and consequently not believing that miracles have happened on earth since the first century. That is why I used the words: "in our unbelieving, revolutionary nineteenth century". Were I a Catholic and had a Catholic's faith, I should no doubt be capable of reconciling my faith with my knowledge; for I am not answerable to my reason for what I accept in faith. The immutability of the laws of nature is a norm that holds firm only in a constitution of nature to be found in science and on paper, and not in the actual constitution of the world, to which I in my existence stand as an obedient subject. Against that constitution no miracle offends which faith declares holy and which strengthens the conviction that the whole is absolutely dependent on unconditioned omnipotence." In other words: Mr. A. too is of the opinion that in and of itself the immutability of the laws of nature is no obstacle to roasted pigeons flying into our mouths. He does not expect it to happen, but only because the time in which such things occurred is over.

When one points out to one of our Neo-Orthodox — who will not grant reason or science the feeblest right to have a say about religion's object — that in our day it will not do to hold fast to stories such as the one about the origin of languages from the deity's

wrath at a presumptuous tower-building, or about the rainbow's coming into being as
 [21] a bodily thing on the occasion of a definite historical or unhistorical event, except as beautiful and poetic legends, the person in question generally answers that the Bible has no intention of teaching us natural science or philology, that it has no intention of enriching our knowledge at all, that this is a wretched misunderstanding, and so on. This answer plainly rests on a mistake. What is said here of the Bible does not hold of the Bible, but of religious proclamation, of the ethical commandment. That does not address itself to our desire for knowledge, and has no intention of imparting to us any information about the origin of languages or of natural phenomena. What the Bible *intends* to teach us is hard to determine^{*)}. But ask simply whether the Bible does not — whether it intends to or not — teach us something of the kind, and the answer is yes; from which it follows that the orthodox man, if he gives up the Bible's authority on these points, has broken once and for all with his principle.

[22] It might now seem as though a disciple of Prof. Nielsen would in this case be able to escape entirely the difficulties in which the orthodox man finds himself entangled. For no one has drawn a sharper distinction than theology's tireless antagonist between what concerns the religious consciousness and what does not. One would expect that these facts, being without significance for the religious life, must on Prof. N.'s doctrine fall to science's criticism and so lose their exceptional standing. But no: it turns out that they are regarded as holy matters of fact. They are preserved in full inviolability, mummies of a faith that will not give up even what is dead; and it is — however unintelligible it sounds — the ethical in man, the ethical demand, that secures these corpses against critical dissolution. The fundamental ethical demand necessitates an ethical ideal; the good cannot exist without one who is good, the absolutely good one only as omnipotent, the omnipotent one only as absolutely creating, and creation in turn can only have taken place in the six days (see Heegaard, *op. cit.*, p. 392). With this the first links are forged of the chain that must presumably be thought to bind together all the holy facts of the Old and New Testaments. The chain has not been completed yet, but the demonstration of the whole nexus will not, one hopes, keep us waiting too long; and then the complete assemblage will lie before us as a fully executed system — which it will not be advisable
 [23] for anyone to venture to call theological. So if one asks Prof. Nielsen's disciple: Can one

^{*)}That such an expression is frequently heard is only one among many testimonies to the highly incorrect usage that has crept in among us, by virtue of which people speak, among other things, of *faith*, *religion*, *science*, *the will* as though these were personal beings. Examples of this metaphor-philosophy are furnished in the richest measure by Dr. Heegaard's "Indledning til Ethiken". Just one here: when on p. 446 he declares that the will's concentration out beyond the rational is a step in which the will raises for itself no theoretical scruple whatever, one is put in mind of the old saying: virtue is no peach. One might with the same right speak of steps in which the heart does not trouble its head in the least.

reject the Old Testament's story of the Babylonian confusion of tongues, or the New Testament's story of the casting out of demons, and still stand in relation to the ethical and religious ideal? — then in the bewilderment of the first moment he will perhaps answer yes; but as soon as he has collected himself he will consistently deny it: the ethical cannot do without the religious, the religious cannot do without revelation, revelation cannot do without these presuppositions. Suppose one then objected: Do try for once to look at the thing freely and squarely; judge without any side considerations — do you accept these facts or not? The answer would necessarily run about as follows: "A plain yes or no I cannot give to your question; for I should otherwise be making knowledge the judge of things that lie outside its competence. As a truthful man I assume, in the interest of truth, that these so-called facts are quite unhistorical; but as a moral individuality I assume, in the name of the good, that these same facts are completely reliable and real."

"But," the questioner bursts out, "do you not see that there is a third and simpler way of regarding such accounts? I am not asking you whether they are true, for with the word truth all manner of tricks can be played; answer only whether you hold that what they report ever happened. Do you believe that the rainbow was set in the heavens, or do you not believe it? Do you believe that those madmen were possessed by demons, or do you not?" Then the answer comes again: "In the interest of the true I assume, and [24] so forth; in the name of the good I hold fast, on the contrary" — and with that the conversation must be at an end. But here even the most conciliatory mind comes to recall the little sharp verse:

"The sun of Spirit, or the parson's taper?
Yes or no! and none of your vapour!"

2. Absolute Heterogeneity.

It falls out fortunately or unfortunately, according to the standpoint one occupies, that [25] Prof. R. Nielsen places at the head of his doctrine of the relation between the religious and the scientific a fundamental proposition on which the whole edifice rests. One does not, then, have to hunt laboriously for the theory's governing thought; it is expressed so definitely that it cannot possibly be missed. And if one cannot go along with it, one need not get involved with the rest: for either that thought is carried through consistently, in which case it will permeate the whole development and at every point make it impossible for one to adopt it, or else it is not unfolded consistently, and then one can wish even less for a closer acquaintance with the details. The proposition, which in a number of articles in "Fædrelandet" has been called a plain self-contradiction, runs as follows: the same consciousness can without contradiction unite faith and knowledge as absolutely heterogeneous principles. "Without contradiction" — that is the safety valve fitted to keep the proposition from blowing up, and the investigation to be undertaken here aims [26] only at testing whether the ventilation is sufficient. The proposition put forward is a fundamental one; but it is hardly too bold to ask what it rests on. It must presumably rest on the general propositions *that two absolutely heterogeneous utterances can in general be utterances of the same thing* — faith and knowledge are, after all, utterances in principle, i.e. utterances of one being — *and that two absolutely heterogeneous principles can in general* — shall we pass over "without contradiction"? — *be united in one and the same consciousness*. Suppose for a moment that this last proposition were true: why then does it say "can" and not "must"? If they can be united, then they can also fail to be united, and so there is no necessity that compels. And does not the same hold when one takes the two definite principles, faith and knowledge? Beyond doubt: one can unite them and one can leave it be, i.e. the union has no universal validity. But if that is how matters stand, what brings it about that the man who does unite them really unites what can be united? The question here is whether that can be made *clear*. Since the quarrel and the reconciliation between faith and knowledge have been carried by Prof. Nielsen out of the domain of science and over into that of "existence", it has become hard to keep an

eye on how the thing is actually conceived; for of existence one may use the old phrase [27] that Hegel used of Schelling's absolute: it is the night in which all cats are grey. The so-called existential, which lays so strong a claim to count as life's true full-blooded concretion, is in reality just the opposite: a pure abstraction, namely what is left over when one subtracts from the existence of the human spirit *in toto* everything theoretical. It is therefore just as far from being true that the human being who exists *sensu eminenti*, in the current philosophical jargon, leads a true and genuine human life, as it is that a dog from which a naturalist has experimentally removed part of the brain can be said to live its life wholly and really. What goes on in "existence" can accordingly be checked neither easily nor with certainty. But since Prof. Nielsen wants clarity above all, it will of course not do for him at any point — and least of all at the decisive one — to put out the light so that nobody can see what is happening, and to light it again only once whatever was to be carried in and out in the theory's interest has been carried in and out. What is it, then, that brings the possible union into being? Why, what is there to resort to here but the crassest immediacy, personal need, which at least *can* be regarded as an entirely individual matter. So this is the philosophical marvel that so large a chorus has hailed: a higher brutalism on the basis of instinct, of immediate assurance, or something else of the sort. If we are to accept this doctrine, let us first give up being spirits!

[28] In taking refuge in immediate practice, which as such is without universal validity, one is entitled to satisfy one's personal need as one pleases. But although the consequence is undeniably this, Prof. Nielsen does not draw it outright. What, then, is the source from which the philosopher draws the content that fills out one of the two empty frames set up in the general proposition? It is revelation, scripture, religion — by which is meant, without further ado, the Christian revelation, scripture and religion as these are understood in Protestant countries, and as they have latterly been understood in Denmark in particular. The man of science who takes Prof. Nielsen's theory for his guide can manage this only by conducting himself as a subtle spirit and then, in a twinkling, turning into a charcoal-burner who answers one's objections with a broad smile: what a man believes, he believes, and no talk about it — and then, when the gust has blown over, throwing off the jerkin, washing, combing his hair, putting on a black coat and being a subtle spirit again. If anyone should commit the blasphemy of asking what *concept* one is to form of a revelation in general, and of the Christian one in particular, then one is a charcoal-burner and says: what stands written, stands written. If it says that one is to bake one's own bread, then one is to bake one's own bread; if it says nothing about brewing one's own beer, then one need have no scruples about the beer. If it says that

one is to repent one's sins, then one is to repent one's sins; if it says that God created the world in 6 days, then he did it in 6 days, for had it said that he had done it in 7 or 14 days, then he would have done it in 7 or 14 days, and so on. (See Dr. Heegaard's presentation of Prof. Nielsen's doctrine, "Indledn. til Ethiken" p. 392.) Revelation is a paradox, an absolute paradox, and as such without any rationality whatever. So do not ask: what is a revelation? Or: may one draw consequences from what is given in a revelation? Or: how far may one draw them? Such questions are asked by reasonable people, but there is no art in being reasonable. The art is, the moment such questions are raised, to clap the wishing-cap on one's head — and then one is a charcoal-burner, if that is what one wants. For it goes without saying: if one is entitled to go so much as a single line beyond the boundaries drawn by revelation's words (6, not 7 or 14), then the extraordinary vanishes and the standpoint has been given up. — So: one is a charcoal-burner, and that is the one side of the matter. If one stopped there, one might still be an object of sympathy and respect. Respect for the charcoal-burner who is in truth what he calls himself! Honour to him when, like the charcoal-burners in Ploug's "Fredericiaslaget", he goes straight at his mark and strikes for his banner with charcoal-burner's fists and charcoal-burner's faith! But when, at the same time as he is a charcoal-burner, he is also to be the scientifically cultivated man, then his claim to be regarded as a figure cast in one piece must outrage every truth-loving mind. [29]

It stands written, after all, that death came into the world through sin. The orthodox understanding of this is that death stands in no essential relation to the human organism: had the first human beings not sinned, their bodies would have been imperishable, indissoluble, unassailable by sickness and decay. But they sinned, and with that this state of perfection was forfeited. Modern science has long been clear not only that death struck manifold animal species before human beings were formed, but that death stands in a necessary relation to organic life. Here, then, science and orthodoxy flatly contradict one another. Against orthodoxy's "death came into the world with sin" science sets its "no! death did not come into the world with sin", just as against orthodoxy's "the world was created in 6 days" it sets its "no! the world was not created in 6 days, since thousands of years passed before the earth became what it is"). Now Prof. Nielsen's claim [30]

^{*)}When Prof. N. (Grundid. s. Logik II p. 456) expresses himself as follows: It stands firm, provided only that one will not let science's "redemption" juggle with faith, that pain and death existed for millions of years before man appeared on earth. And it stands firm, provided only that one will not let faith's "redemption" juggle with knowledge, that death is the wages of sin and nature's corruptibility a transgression of spirit" — then orthodoxy's hard proposition has here either evaporated into a piece of pure wit, into a bold designation of the indisputable kinship between sin and death, or else the reconciliation is wholly unintelligible. And when Dr. Heegaard (Indledn. til Eth. p. 394) declares that one must hold on to the 6 days, because one surely cannot be a believing geologist or a geological believer, this is a poor and empty

is that one can without contradiction unite two such propositions in one's consciousness. What is it, then, that brings about this astonishing result? Answer: they are absolutely heterogeneous.

One scarcely knows what to wonder at most in this answer: *at* such propositions really being given out as absolutely heterogeneous, or *at* absolutely heterogeneous phenomena being able to be housed in one I at all, or finally *at* the absolute heterogeneity itself being the ground of the peaceable relation between them. One grasps this much: that those propositions are to be able to subsist side by side in amity because they are to be kept so carefully apart that they never come into contact at all. And one sees, perhaps — in parenthesis — a nemesis upon the dialectician who formerly went to such extremes in his dialecticising, in the fact that here it is a criticism that is to rescue the [32] theory. One understands well enough, too, that the propositions' absolute heterogeneity may be the ground of their not being able to contradict one another, since the condition of their doing so would have to be that they could be compared, and that presupposes homogeneity up to a certain degree. (Homogeneity of course includes heterogeneity within it and is always relative; otherwise it would be sameness.) But what one does not see at all is that absolute heterogeneity can be the ground of two principles, utterances, propositions being reconciled. On the contrary, it is a decisive ground for their not being reconcilable at all, since they cannot so much as enter into relation with one another. Absolute heterogeneity is another expression for absolute irreconcilability. Prof. Nielsen might therefore just as well have given his proposition this form: absolutely irreconcilable principles can be reconciled, or can be not absolutely irreconcilable — all without contradiction. He has said it, but in other words. When at the time, in "Fædrelandet", I branded it a self-contradiction to have faith and knowledge united in the same consciousness once they are determined as absolutely heterogeneous principles, people rose from several quarters, ready to show me with confident superiority that my attack on Prof. Nielsen rested on a complete misunderstanding: where I put an *although*, the Professor put a *because*, and so forth^{*)}. There is a way of inferring that is just as [33] dangerous and at least just as common as the hothead's "I cannot understand that man, consequently he is wrong": it is the echoer's "I understand this man, consequently he is right". The pupil begins by standing astonished, uncertain, full of questions and doubts before his teacher's discourse; but when it then dawns on him — often all at once — how

play on words; for whoever — be it as believer or as knower — assumes anything whatever about the earth's coming to be has an assumption that geology can correct.

^{*)}see Høffding: "Philosophie og Theologie" p. 41. R. Schmidt: "Om Selvmødsigelsen o. s. v." p. 17. Heegaard: Indledn. t. d. r. Ethik p. 389.

the teacher actually conceives the matter, in what way he wants what he has set out to be understood, then, in his joy at grasping what was a riddle to many and so lately to himself, he becomes at that very moment an adherent, and the more unconditionally the less independent he is by nature. Such a pupil of course traces every objection to his master's doctrine, in the most favourable case, to misunderstanding and ignorance, and in the worst case to a moral depravity; and one must make some allowance for his standpoint: that anyone might understand what the teacher meant and still have something to object to it has not entered his boldest dreams. So I am supposed not to have understood that the absolute heterogeneity was precisely the condition of the much-discussed reconciliation. Although I developed my view at that time in fair detail, and in particular did not — as Mr. Clemens Petersen has lately stated untruthfully — withdraw when my opponent “made as if to carry the matter into a thoroughgoing discussion”, I shall nevertheless take this point of dispute up again here. The matter is quite simple. If two propositions such as a) “the world was created in 6 days” and b) “the world was not created in 6 days” are [34] absolutely heterogeneous, then this is the same as saying that the one is an utterance of a being (*essentia*) that is absolutely heterogeneous with the being of which the other is an utterance. *Fiat applicatio* — the R. Nielsen who states proposition a is absolutely another than (heterogeneous with) the one who states proposition b; to call them both by the same name is an innocent amusement, like Hostrup's conceit in “Soldaterløier” of calling all three heirs Peter. That Prof. Nielsen calls himself by the same name in both cases is a caprice one may allow him, so long as one takes care not to be led astray by it. Here, however, we have not merely two persons, but two persons each belonging to a world absolutely heterogeneous with the other's; for every splitting of a subject is a splitting of the whole objective world that mirrors itself in the subject, since the subject is in the last instance an utterance of that world. If the subject is divided, that comes in principle of the whole world's having split (*essentia*) beforehand. One ought not, then, to ask how matters stand with a man's self-consciousness when he houses fundamental views that contradict one another in this way; for such a man cannot exist. Absolute heterogeneity is absolute dualism; but absolute dualism is a masquerade joke, a dummy concealing a real homogeneity and unity.

Since, from the standpoint once taken up, one does not go outside the features that revelation comprises, one cannot exhibit its absurdity any further: the Christian [35] revelation does after all contain — considering the new doctrine — an astonishing quantity of rational truths that will not be docked to fit the paradoxes now so much in

favour^{*)}. If, on the other hand, one places oneself — as one is entitled to do — *outside* the standpoint (Christian revelation) but *on* its fundamental proposition in that proposition's general form (the possibility of absolutely heterogeneous utterances being united), there is infinite play for the wildest attempts to satisfy the practical interest, the personal need. Such attempts have been made already: witness the manifold positive religions, which
 [36] outdo actual fairy tales in fabulousness, and yet precisely are the fruit of the deepest personal need. All of these Prof. Nielsen must let stand; whether they have a rational content of ideas or not makes no odds from a supra-rational standpoint. One cannot even say: the madder the better — for everything may claim equal rank where personal need, purged or cleansed of all reason, is the measure. That a man, as worshipper of his God and devotee of his science, asserts absolutely conflicting statements is, from the middle of the nineteenth century onward, no obstacle to his uttering the clear, indeed the highest, truth. It is Denmark that has the honour of this discovery, beside which one may perhaps set N. F. S. Grundtvig's, but assuredly neither Ole Rømer's nor H. C. Ørsted's.

But one need not stop here; the positive religions have no exclusive right to the satisfaction of the anti-rational need. It is my need and nobody else's that I have to satisfy; and if I thereby come to live in a swarm of absolutely heterogeneous utterances, what of it? It conflicts with reason, with thought. Reason! Thought! They have no vote where the highest is at stake. One may choose whichever contradictory assumption one likes; once one declares it demanded by one's personal, one's ethical need, Prof. Nielsen can raise no objection to it. To make this vivid, one single supra-rational instance. Suppose a man has the personal faith that Martin Luther was an incarnation — not, let us say, of
 [37] the whole world-principle, but of the Sirius-principle, say; and suppose that for the same man, as knower, Luther was the well-known reformer who has nothing whatever to do with the Sirius-principle. What good will it do then to call such a thing unreasonable and unnatural? Probability and reason have nothing to say on this point. Or would the philosopher really look for reassurance in the thought that nobody will hit upon sheer absurdities? Would he be reduced to appealing to probability — that hereditary enemy

^{*)}On this point the unhappiest abuse of words has been carried on in our more recent literature, in that every truth uttered in the New Testament is described as not having arisen in any human being's heart or brain. Every proposition that human beings can grasp and understand must, however, have been conceived by human beings in the first place; for producing and grasping are one and the same thing seen from two different sides. Next, every such truth is described as paradoxical, as opposed to the human: thus it is supposed to be a paradoxical, a positively Christian proposition that one should love one's enemies. But in reality it conflicts not with understanding or reason at all, but with sensuousness; that one should not repay evil with evil is a pure command of reason. If everything that comes into conflict with our sensuous drive were paradoxical, then reason itself would be the paradoxical.

of the paradoxical — to the probability that nobody will hit upon anything that conflicts with reason to that degree? For reason is, after all, the only thing that could have any objection to such assumptions; supra-reason would behold everything, and behold, it was very good. Is the champion of principles really to be reduced to wanting in principle, to the last extreme, what he most firmly refuses to have in reality?

Since the whole strange doctrine is so hard to make plain when one goes straight at the matter, adherents of Prof. Nielsen have from time to time done the public the kindness of illuminating the relation by images or analogies. Without dwelling on how precarious such illumination is by its very nature, we shall simply see with what success it has been attempted. So as to leave nothing relevant unmentioned, I will recall that Mr. Clemens Petersen some years ago presented the relation between representation and concept in the religious domain by the following image. When, it ran roughly, a man sees [38] a mill-sail turning on its axis, and one asks him whether the outermost or the innermost part of the sail has the faster motion, then, if he goes by the sensory impression, he will involuntarily answer: they go equally fast [?]; whereas grasped conceptually the outer end of course travels much faster than the inner. Just as little, it went on, as one ought to “torment representation into seeing the concept”, just as little ought one to force representation’s illusion upon thought. And so too in religion: there is one truth for representation, another, contradicting the first, for thought, and neither does the other any damage. — That was the parable. One sees that it answers to Prof. Nielsen’s theory, and that Mr. Petersen accordingly has — as not many know — some other merit in this affair than that of being the Professor’s panegyrist. If one may draw an inference from his parable, the religious representations turn out to be so many deceptions of the senses, of a doubtful unavoidability. Mr. Petersen, however, seems to have meant to establish something quite different.

Next, Dr. Heegaard (Indledn. til Ethiken p. 389) has supplied an illuminating parallel. His words are these: “At this (the contemplative) stage in consciousness no conflict *can* arise between faith and knowledge, precisely *because* they are heterogeneous, and not, as by a strange misunderstanding has repeatedly (sic!) been maintained, *although* they are heterogeneous principles; for this ‘although’ implies that the spheres of faith [39] and knowledge should be *able* to bound one another, which is impossible so long as consciousness hovers above them. Let us take an example: the contemplative consciousness can without contradiction house at one and the same time an aesthetic and an astronomical problem, not although but precisely because they are heterogeneous; it cannot of course have them both in consciousness at the same time, but it can immerse

itself in either of them as much as it likes without the one problem ever suffering damage from the other, just because they point back to heterogeneous starting points.” It should be needless to add any commentary on this passage; it must be plain even to the most easily beguiled that there is not so much as a trace of an analogy here. One will notice, incidentally, that Dr. Heegaard carefully refrains from calling the heterogeneity absolute. When I first contested Prof. Nielsen’s use of that expression, Messrs. Schmidt and Høffding vied with one another in explaining to me that this was exactly where the secret lay: had the heterogeneity been relative, it would have been quite another matter, and the reconciliation would have been impossible. Dr. Heegaard, though, seems to have discovered that by laying the stress on this point one passed out of Scylla into Charybdis.

The third and most discussed parallel is the one Mr. Rud. Schmidt has drawn between this relation and the relation between the truth of poetry and the truth of reality. This [40] analogy has rather more interest, since Kierkegaard has perhaps hinted at it in passing — see his use of Gorgias’s saying that the deceived man is wiser than the undeceived, cf. *Afsluttende Efterskrift* p. 349. The question, then, is first and foremost whether the two terms are absolutely heterogeneous. One must answer no at once; for the denial lies already in the very expressions used. If both have truth, then both are moments in the realm of truth, and so far is it from being possible to speak here of absolute heterogeneity that there must even be an element in which poetry and reality are absolutely homogeneous. For if truth is a concept that really can be applied to them — or, to use a more intimate expression, a determination of their essence — then it must permeate them both wholly and entirely, permeate every other determination of theirs. Both are then utterances of a totality that embraces them. So much in general. But it comes out no less clearly when one takes hold of the relation in a definite example. Mr. R. Schmidt has used one which Prof. Nielsen, by not disowning it, has acknowledged as his own. He cites the folk belief that when the meadow steams on a summer morning it is the bog-wife brewing; just as in this case there is for the educated man no contradiction between the poetic belief and the natural-scientific cognition, so too there is no contradiction between the heterogeneous assumptions of faith and knowledge. But in the first place [41] the imaginary meadow and the real meadow are not absolutely heterogeneous, and consequently neither are the corresponding conceptions. Separate the bog from the bog-wife — absolutely, of course — and what is the latter then for the imagination? Folk belief’s personification is nothing but reality’s reflex in the imagination, which must work incessantly with the real in order to bring forth something that is not reality and yet is reality. To understand this one must use dialectic; but in this matter dialectic has

been given over to the gods once and for all. In the second place there is no analogy here. Since the meadow that folk poetry has may in general be described as an imaginary meadow, while the one on which the natural-scientific conception is directed is the real meadow, the two are not related to one and the same object. One might then just as well call it a contradiction of the same kind as the one between faith and knowledge when I say at one and the same time that *I* own Lake Fuur (a painting by N. N.) and that *the state* owns Lake Fuur (the real one). It is another matter if one maintains that the real meadow's steam is an effect of the bog-wife's brewing, and at the same time says that it is just as fully an effect of physical causes: then we have an analogy, a contradiction of the kind in question. For when, say, orthodoxy assumes a human being's elevation from the earth and gradual ascent into the dogmatic heaven, and science denies this miracle, first by virtue of the law of gravitation and second because, however high one may be lifted into the air, one never gets out of this world's astronomical heaven and into the [42] transcendent one, then it is the very same point, the very same ascension, of which both speak. — Nor, then, is the analogy we are seeking to be found here. But leave that aside. Even if one is content, in the analogy's interest, to stress the ease with which in the example used two heterogeneous conceptions glide past one another without mutual influence, one forgets, on the one hand — and this is very bad — that the advance of our cognition of reality makes it impossible to use certain expressions of fantasy that were once serviceable enough^{*)}; and on the other hand one overlooks that the so-called gliding past one another is in reality nothing of the sort, but would rather have to be determined as the one conception's penetration into the other's lacunae or pores, made possible by the fact that neither of them is quite complete. This is why, for instance, the poet has the freer hand with historical material the less known it is to his public; if the public must be presumed familiar with every small feature of the material, he will necessarily be very much bound. It would, however, be what Kierkegaard calls "running off into parentheses" to enter on a closer discussion of this in connection with the question that [43] matters. The decisive thing is and remains that the poetic illusion, as a complete unicum, is no analogy at all. It is, be it noted, only poetic when it momentarily alternates between being and being cancelled; it is, be it noted, only poetic in so far as it is conscious. The birds that peck at painted berries, or the lazzaroni in Naples's little theatres who give away the hero by their gestures when the villain has hidden, have not attained the poetic illusion. The strangest thing, however, is that the defenders of this analogy would be in

^{*)}See Ørsted: Aanden i Naturen II. p. 4. "For an imagination that has made its own a living, present picture of the world system, the expression the foundation of the earth is no better than the foundation of a well-hung chandelier, but if possible even less fitting".

the worst straits of all if one were to hold them to it in earnest. For anyone who means to ascribe the fullest reality to some definite religious representation has acted against himself as soon as he sets it beside the purely imaginary — be the latter never so beautiful and never so significant, both far more beautiful and far less foggy than the bog-wife's brew. If, on the other hand, the bog-wife is transformed into a real person, then we have one of those anti-rational truths before which Prof. Nielsen must consistently bow; and then the game is in full swing with the two truths that Prof. Nielsen champions in plain Danish but combats when they appear as the Middle Ages' *duæ veritates*.

If we now look back at what has been objected here to the new doctrine, what [44] significance is left to the whole array of absolutely heterogeneous principles, utterances, truths — or whatever one is to call these ill-placed beings? Might it not be with them as with the villages that Potemkin showed his empress as evidence of the district's flourishing condition? They were, in the proper sense, merely set up, for they did not exist. Subjectively regarded, there cannot possibly be absolutely heterogeneous objects for us: considered as causes, they would have to call forth absolutely heterogeneous utterances of consciousness in a subject that would consequently be wholly split. Can then, objectively regarded, any utterance whatever that issues from a principle of existence, or from a sum of objects forming a totality, be absolutely heterogeneous with any other whatever? Think it, and you fall into self-contradiction, since you posit a whole and deny what follows from it. To be is to be comprised within an existence; when absolutely heterogeneous objects *are*, then they are not absolutely heterogeneous. Make the trial with whatever objects, utterances, fantasies or what you will, and you will find that even if they exclude one another in one respect, they nonetheless do not do so in another, at any rate in so far as they can both fall within one subject. Try: "a yellow symphony" — that cannot be said, and yet tone and colour are essentially homogeneous as wave phenomena; "an equilateral right-angled triangle" — there is no such thing, and yet both adjectives designate possible [45] determinations of the concept triangle^{*)}. Take what has no significance whatever: the meaningless, the non-existent. Separate it absolutely from what is, and it cannot even be uttered; even this, which would seem to have a privilege of existing in separation from its opposite, is nothing but a reflex of that opposite. But when heterogeneity in the absolute sense has no power even here, how much less has it power there, where existence and reality are ascribed to everything.

^{*)}Not even such pronounced opponents as the poets Mr. Henrik Scharling and Mr. Rud. Schmidt are absolutely heterogeneous. On the contrary, there are points at which an absolute homogeneity obtains between them. Mr. Schmidt hits upon such a point with great assurance when in his book "Er Hr. Lic. Henrik Scharling en alvorlig Mand?" p. 80 he advances the conjecture that Mr. Scharling has now "as usual written us something bad".

One would do me a great injustice in supposing that in putting forward purely elementary truths like these I have for a moment imagined myself to be teaching a thinker like Prof. Nielsen something he did not know quite as well himself, something he has not himself said long before I had any inkling of it. I owe it in large part to Prof. Nielsen himself that I am in a position to contradict him. But it is not so with truth that one who has communicated it as one of its organs can afterwards take his gift back at pleasure, when as a weapon even in the weakest hand it would be strong enough to disturb a boldly designed theory raised on a fragile foundation — a theory [46] that will hamper spiritual advance, that will bar the way to every effort to bring about harmony between reason and religion, between the human spirit's intellectual and its ethical-religious demands, and that thereby disturbs all work toward the solution of one of the human race's great tasks for the future.

3. The Anti-Rational.

One can tell oneself what must follow when a thinker overlooks those elementary truths [47] and, for the sake of a personal need that becomes — once universal validity is ascribed to it — an idiosyncrasy tormenting and oppressing others, attempts to hold fast to what cannot be held. The consequence has shown itself already. It is an anarchy of concepts, a confusion of concepts that undermines the ground on which our science is built, and of which the theories of Dr. Heegaard are surely the most desperate expression that any literature has to show in that line. For what have we now? We have the well-known metaphysics and the well-known logic with their concepts: freeborn, children of nature and reason, living their life in a world in which they are ordered as members and where their essence unfolds and comes into its own. And then on the other side we have a world where they must do the lowest bondsman's service — the service, namely, in which the bondsman must deny his origin and his essence. For these same concepts and powers are employed in the anti-rational world in such a way that they may express nothing rational at all. For if they do express something rational, they at once transform [48] the impotent powers for which they are to do forced labour — the so-called categories: the paradoxical, the anti-rational, the positive — into rational magnitudes, which is what those powers dread as certain beings in the legend dread the daylight. Those children of light are therefore compelled to put out their own light as well, so that the desired darkness may reign. Take whichever concepts you like: principle, law, consequence — they are employed so that they shall express nothing of their essential content, indeed so that they shall express *nothing* at all, in order that they may designate what their tyrants are. For the tyrants are nothing apart from those they have subjugated, and even when they have subjugated them they are nothing but wretchedness all the same: they must borrow everything from others — the shirt off their backs, as the saying goes — and then they give themselves the air of being the real capitalists of the spiritual life, or rather, they are given out to be such.

The moment one really takes the doctrine of the anti-rational at its word, all discussion stops, and indeed all communication. And this happens not because one has failed to

understand Prof. Nielsen properly, but precisely when one has understood him properly: one could not misunderstand him more grossly than by setting about to debate the matter with him, and he could not set a beginner a harder test than by inviting him to a joint debate. That this is how things stand I shall try to show — taking care, of course, [49] not to fall into the snare that the matter by its very nature lays for anyone who gets involved with it.

In the first place, all communication is made impossible. When a freemason wants to find out whether another man is a freemason, he does not ask him about it, nor does he say that he is one himself; he uses no words at all to give and receive this communication. He may talk of wind and weather, of trade and politics, indeed he may even talk of freemasonry; but if he means to reach his goal, he uses a means of communication lying quite outside language: he contrives an opportunity to give the other's hand a peculiar pressure. If the man in question is not a freemason, he notices merely a pressure, or notices nothing at all; if he is a freemason, he understands the communication and communicates in return. It stands similarly with the anti-rational religious ethicist. He can no more communicate through language than the freemason can, language being a system of signs for determinations of thought and reason; but since on the other hand he cannot, like the freemason, use his hand instead of the word, he chooses language's words to designate something that is as independent of the rational determinations they designate as the freemason's communication is of the handshake he gives. For that something exists only for the organ of the anti-rational-religious, and does not exist at all for the reason of which language is the expression and the means of communication. [50] Now if that something cannot be communicated through language, then of course it can as little be communicated by any other means that stands under the law of the rational; the path of the communication is a secret to everyone who does not possess the organ. If one asks why language is used at all, this must doubtless — for that too is a secret — be regarded as an incitement by which the secret communication may take effect; if, on the other hand, one asks why language in particular is used, the question is an unintelligent one, since the same question could be raised about every other rational means, while about the secret means no question can be raised at all, asking being a rational act.

Let us see the correctness of this in some examples. When, for instance, there is talk of an anti-rational-religious ethics, then the word ethics, in the mouth of the anti-rational-religious man and for his ear, does designate the rational determination that the word expresses; but for the anti-rational-religious organ it designates something quite different, which we — precisely because it falls outside all reason — cannot possibly designate

here. When it is said further that the paradoxical ethics “dialectically understood has its rational side”^{*)}, then in the first place the word dialectically cannot designate the rational determination of which it is the expression; it designates a peculiarity of the anti-rational that can be grasped only by the organ, and which the organ takes up into [51] itself, occasioned by reason’s apprehending what the word expresses. In the second place the word rational can in no way carry its accepted meaning; it merely indicates a further peculiarity, for whose reception by the organ the determination “the rational” is an incitement. And when it is said, finally,^{*)} that the anti-rational in ethics emerges as a consequence of the rational, then the word consequence here of course does not designate what it appears to designate, but yet another new and interesting peculiarity of the anti-rational, to whose reception the rational determination “consequence” incites. Indeed, this holds even of the expression “the anti-rational” itself. It is anti-rational only for thought and reason; so that for whose apprehension it is an incitement cannot be the anti-rational, but is something about whose relation to thought, about whose validity or invalidity for thought, there can be no question at all, since its peculiarity is in each and every respect only for the organ. And so throughout: the words with their rational determinations are so many incitements occasioning the anti-rational-religious organ’s many peculiar functions, of which these words are in no way the expression; and whatever those functions may be, communicated they cannot be.

The very thing that is the reason why the anti-rational cannot be communicated also grounds its not being capable of objectification, and indeed of not being thought at all, or made the object of any cognition in which thinking is a moment. The reason [52] is that it falls absolutely outside all rationality. That the stress must fall on “absolutely” goes without saying, since nothing in existence is exhausted by rationality, and since the rational everywhere presupposes the real, without which it possesses no reality itself. But the rational and the real permeate one another, so that they belong to one another’s essence; or, more precisely: it is one and the same essence that distinguishes itself into its two essential sides. The rational therefore stands under the law of the real, and the real under the law of the rational. If, then, there shows itself a real that wholly withdraws from the law of the rational, then of course no rational determination can express its essence in the least degree, and it can exist neither for thinking — which relates itself to the ideal — nor for the cognition that corresponds to the real, because thinking is everywhere a moment in that cognition, just as the ideal is everywhere a moment in the real. The determination “the real” can then be applied to the anti-rational as little as any

^{*)}Heegaard, op. cit. p. 439.

^{*)}Heegaard p. 406, 439, 445.

other; like those mentioned earlier, it is only an incitement for the organ to function in some definite direction. The same then holds of the word function, and of the remaining expressions, all of which designate something in which there is a rational element.

If the anti-rational is not understood in this way, it is transformed into a rational; [53] for a rational is a something that is real, a real is a something that is rational, but an anti-rational is a something that is neither real nor rational, that is not an anti-rational — that may indeed be called so, but is not really rightly so called, since it can have nothing whatever to do with the expression by which it is named. From which it follows, too, that no science can be formed about it. A system of thoughts can very well be formed, but this will mean no more than a system of incitements to the anti-rational's mysterious working, which those thoughts do not express at all — to which belongs the point that the word incitement likewise expresses nothing concerning the relation between the rational and the anti-rational, since there is no relation whatever. That no criticism can be given of the anti-rational's presentation, since no presentation of it can be found; and that no discussion can be conceived with the man who stands at the anti-rational's standpoint — of this one now needs only to be reminded, since criticism and discussion are acts standing under the law of the rational.

If we recall, finally, that knowing is a rational act — which is not the same as a merely rational one — then it follows of itself that we know no real that is not at the same time rational. We therefore do not *know* any anti-rational, and know no organ for the anti-rational. Is it then not at all? No; for being has a rational side, and to say that the [54] anti-rational is, is to say that it is rational. What, then, are we to say of it? We can say nothing; we can as little affirm as deny anything about it. And one must remember above all that what has been said of it here expresses nothing about its essence, and is absolutely and unconditionally foreign to it.

4. The Consequences of Dualism.

When a small, almost invisible crack has appeared in a glass, it can sometimes, after [55] holding at the same point for a long while, run through all at once and split the whole glass. When one of the human body's extremities is attacked by a disease, the damage can eat its way from that starting point into the body and attack its health at the root. So it has gone with the dualism that showed itself early^{*)} in Prof. Nielsen's view of the relation between faith and knowledge. For a long time it seemed harmless to his theory, since it did not concern the theory itself; it rested only on the fact that the theory gained no influence over his practice. But now it has broken through so vigorously that it has penetrated into his fundamental philosophical view itself^{**)}. In one sense this might seem strange: one would think it could have no effect on the philosopher's doctrinal edifice [56] that outside his science he entertained an unscientific conviction. Even if Prof. Nielsen were to go so far as to forbid us to apply the theory he has given us — well, one might say, let us at least be theoretical within theory. And if that were not the intention, why else has the Professor so often and with such great pleasure told us the anecdote of Laplace's answer to Napoleon's question? Would it not be most remarkable if the philosopher who has so strongly stressed science's protest against any dogma whatever should end, like Victor Cousin in France, by offering his concept of God "comme une base, qui peut porter la trinité chrétienne"?^{*)} But the fact is that precisely because the separation Prof. Nielsen means to install between life and science is so chimerical, precisely for that reason the split in existence, the "psychological" discord, reaches right into science, where it ought not to be able to reach at all. In his "Bemærkninger om theoretisk og praktisk Erkjendelse" the Professor has let the split pass over from the religious domain to the ethical, and from the ethical to that of cognition. Here it is then not merely religion and science, but acting and knowing, and within cognition again the theoretical and the "practical" cognition, that stand over against one another as absolutely heterogeneous. Matters

^{*)}Phil. Propædeutik 1857 p. 77.

^{**)}Bemærkninger om theoretisk og praktisk Erkjendelse. Nord. Universitetstidsskr. Tillægshäfte til 10de Aargang, 1866. Kjbh.

^{*)}se Grundid. s. Logik II. p. 343.

[57] have taken the same course here as with the paradox. About a paradox, an absolute paradox in and for itself, one may think what one likes; but whatever one thinks, it must surely be plain that a mediated paradox is an utter monstrosity. One will remember, too, how ridiculous Kierkegaard found all “glimpsing” in the face of the absolute paradox (Afsl. Eftskr. p. 433); but what is it other than the drollest “glimpsing” when we are told^{*)} that “the paradoxical standpoint emerges *in virtue of the same law of development as holds within the rational*”, and that “rational science doubles its point of view in such a way that it at once recognises the paradox’s existential incomprehensibility and, precisely in virtue of this recognition, also discovers the law of development according to which science gives a reflection of the paradox’s genesis”^{*)}). Thus the relative paradox comes to prepare the absolute one and to pave the way for it. While it still runs, in Grundid. s. Logik II. p. 278, that “power in its essence is just as rational as knowledge”, and that “the infinite *reason* determines the logical *by the anti-logical* and conversely”, in Dr. Heegaard willing itself, in so far as it is something incommensurable for theoretical knowledge (*an* [58] *anti-logical*), is called “a rational *paradox*” (p. 441), and this fine concept thus forms the desired transition. As the paradoxical has here struck roots right down into immanence’s rational world, so too has absolute heterogeneity.

It is, however, hard enough on this point to extract a sufficiently sharp and decided statement from Prof. Nielsen. He does use strong words, but he is apt to add a little subordinate clause or qualification that robs the words of their “resolute” stamp again; he takes back with one hand what he has given with the other. He fortifies the gulf between practice and theory; he even seems to go so far as to want to deny that theory as such can be carried over into practice at all, for — as it runs — “what is known theoretically cannot be known practically”^{*)}). This claim does seem to be of an incautiousness that has at least this much in its favour, that it is “resolute”. But suppose someone now put the question to the Professor: do you really say that practice cannot be derived from theory? Then he can answer in his own words: by no means, I have only said that practice cannot *directly* be derived from theory^{**)}). And who in all the world would contradict that? In the same way the Professor declared in the introduction to Grundid. s. Logik I that science cannot [59] directly refute the miracle. A valuable category, the category *not directly* — worthy of the man who so sharply reproached speculative dogmatics with “the spongy softness with which the category degree has to figure everywhere, in every dilemma however

^{*)}Heegaards Fremstilling af Prof. Nielsens Lære, Indledn. til Ethiken p. 439.

^{*)}Anf. Sted p. 69.

^{**)}P. 66.

decisive, partly directly, partly indirectly”^{*)}.

Further: the Professor blows the bridge between thought and will sky-high, having first erased feeling’s territory from his map and divided that weaker power’s possessions between those two autocrats. He not only ascribes to will the same originality as to thought (p. 68), but lays such weight on the refutation of the Hegelian error that will is merely a modification of thinking that one would suppose absolute heterogeneity proved as soon as this misunderstanding had been refuted. But the question here is not at all whether will can be derived from thought or thought from will; it is whether both these utterances of essence cannot be derived from one and the same fundamental essence. Deny that, and we have dualism pure and simple. But here too the decisive thing — or rather the lack of any decision — is that in reality it is denied only in appearance. For if one objects that thought and will do after all stand in unbroken relation to one another, the Professor merely answers: why, I have never concealed that, “but thought is not for that reason will, nor will thought, and so forth” (p. 67) — which of course it could not occur to any human being to deny. If one then, so as to get back to the [60] centre, tries turning the Professor’s own words against him as follows: if “religion presupposes a revelation and revelation a miracle, while science denies the miracle and rejects revelation” (p. 63), then the form of the religious that can be united with science can only be one without miracles and without revelation — then Prof. Nielsen answers bitterly that “such exhortations are more characteristic of the lively heads than of the thorough ones” (p. 73), notwithstanding that it is he himself who has set up the premises from which this conclusion must necessarily be drawn. And if one then loses heart and objects at the last only that the Professor’s view must after all be an open dualism, the author of the “Bemærkninger” can answer with justice: why, I say so myself, I am pretty nearly a dualist — for, as it runs, “there are in the life of spirit strong oppositions bordering on dualism” (p. 66). Pretty-nearly-dualism is a relative of what Prof. N. calls “middle-way theology”: one cannot catch it, being so supple that it slips out of the hands of anyone who means to grasp it.

They are fine, true and inspired words that the author of *Grundideernes Logik* utters in the second part, p. 457: “A feeble idea naturally has feeble extremes with a weak middle and a feeble conclusion, and that is why immanent speculation is always so anxious about anything that might resemble a dualism. The mighty idea, divine in essence, on the contrary has mighty extremes; its issuing in a vigorous dualism is merely [61] the presupposition of the infinite superiority with which it completes the conclusion.”

^{*)}Phil. Propædeutik. Efteraarshalvaar 1865 p. 173.

But what does it help us that these words are true, when in the psychological sphere the “conclusion” fails to arrive and irreconcilable contradictions are set face to face with one another? We all owe Prof. Nielsen thanks and recognition for the energy with which he has pursued the ideal right out into the utmost extreme of its opposite, and admiration for the brilliant confidence with which he has always felt assured that it must after all prove possible to show the unity of even the most conflicting things within the mighty idea. We hear him without resentment speak scornfully of those who would take fright at the very shadow of a dualism — but only, it goes without saying, so long as the real dualism is not given out, like the man in the fairy tale, for its own shadow. Once the teacher’s confidence has become over-confidence, the pupil’s security gives way before the feeling of a real sundering: a split that cannot be hidden under indefinite turns of phrase like the ones just cited, a breach that can by no means be riveted by the kind of dialectic that consists in forcing contradictory expressions together, such as “rational paradox” or “absolutely heterogeneous utterances that turn out to be relative”^{*)}.

- [62] Fortunately the author of the “Bemærkninger” does not content himself with stating general propositions; he chooses definite examples to illustrate what he has advanced. But, as was to be expected in so precarious a matter, Prof. N. is strangely unlucky in the examples he gives. He expresses himself (p. 69) in the following way: “Categories such as freedom of choice, choice, resolution and the like do indeed fall under thought’s illumination, in so far as they become clear in ethical cognition; but in principle they are none the less categories of will, and their cognition is essentially practical. What is known theoretically cannot be known practically; it is no use appealing to the fact that the content known is the same and only the mode of cognition different, for in every decisive cognition the content is determined by the mode, and the mode by the content. That courage as a virtue can be known in theory must be granted; — but if the courage that is known theoretically really were in each and every respect the same, the very same, as the courage that is known practically, what would follow from that? It would follow that a capable theoretical thinker, without venturing anything, without exposing his life to any real danger, would have to be able to think himself into true courage so thoroughly that he thereby at the same time thought true courage into himself, and so, by objective thinking, really became courageous, however cowardly he might otherwise be by nature. But that a man who is in reality a coward can no more speculate his way to real courage, however theoretically he may think, than a man without money can,
- [63] though he were to think theoretically and objectively until he burst, speculate his way

^{*)}Bemærkningerne p. 65.

to real money, stands in no need of proof.”

I shall not dwell further on this last example of the money that one is supposed not to be able to speculate one’s way to, though one thought until one — in Prof. N.’s forceful expression — burst. I think one may maintain without chicanery that any merchant, indeed any mere gambler on the exchange who has speculated, could teach Prof. Nielsen that one can speculate oneself into money, and out of it. Or is the point perhaps lodged in the words “theoretically objectively”? I hardly think speculations on the exchange can be reckoned to subjective, ethical-practical thinking. But what I mean to hold to is the example of courage. For this example is a testimony beyond all others to the want of clarity and sober reflection that characterises the whole new doctrine. First a division is made of the categories into categories of will and categories of knowledge; then it is said of the former that their cognition is essentially practical; and then courage is named as an example. That Prof. Nielsen lays weight on this is clear from the fact that the example occurs not only once in the “Bemærkninger” but, in the echo Dr. Heegaard, a full four times, namely pp. 385, 399, 400, 405. Now if courage here meant the intrepidity that can be inborn in one man and denied to another almost as a physical disposition, then anyone would certainly be rightly held up to ridicule who believed that, however [64] cowardly he might be by nature, he could become courageous — by nature — through objective thinking. But what was then said of courage as a *practical* determination would unfortunately hold in the same measure of all the theoretical endowments too; for a man who is by nature slow, sluggish in thought and weakly gifted can just as little speculate his way to inborn aptitude, acuteness or wit. But since the express reference here, as we are told, is to courage as a *virtue*, the determination given is simply false. The theoretical cognition of what truth enjoins, of what a relation of duty is, of what honour requires, of what a fatherland means, can and should pass over into flesh and blood in such a way that it combats and overcomes the natural timidity wherever that stands in the way of doing what is right. Whoever denies this possibility ought not to presume to plead life’s cause against the theories; for he reveals himself as an armchair philosopher, a pure theoretician, however much he may extol and even deify the practical, *however eagerly he strives to make it the one thing needful*.

For rightly considered, what else is Prof. Nielsen doing? He speaks, to be sure, of the double world, and often seems a pure dualist; but in the last instance one will find that it goes with him as with all dualists: they are of necessity dualists only in appearance, and when it comes to the point they are driven to cast away one of the two opposed terms they have brought into unnatural tension with one another. It turns out that Prof. N., [65]

polemicalising against making thought everything and thinking one with the whole man (p. 68), in reality makes another of the human spirit's utterances — namely the life of the will — into everything, into the whole; for if the worst comes to the worst, that side may be sacrificed, but not this one (p. 76). Hear the author's own words: "He who sets thought upon the practical cognition of a holy will may perhaps forfeit theory, but he wins life, spirit's eternal life; for *spirit's life is in the will*". Is it a philosopher speaking, or a priest, a thinker or a moralist? In a man who speaks with an ethical or godly purpose in view one finds such an expression justified and gladly approves it; but in a man who means to *explain* existence to us as a thinker?

One ought perhaps to wonder at it less, since quite corresponding aberrations are met with in other literatures too. See for instance Taine: "Les philosophes français du XIX^e siècle" on Maine de Biran p. 59: Il n'observe que le moi, l'âme, l'être, la substance. Où les trouve-t-il? Dans la volonté.... Ainsi le moi n'est plus ce tout indivisible et continu, dont nos idées, nos plaisirs, nos peines sont les parties composantes, isolées par fiction et par analyse. c'est une force ou faculté, portion du tout, mise à part, élevée au-dessus de toutes les autres. Le reste est mon bien: celle-ci est moi". In this way the [66] witty Frenchman characterises this doctrine, which makes the will into the whole man. But although the phenomenon is thus not unique, I must confess that I for my part was highly astonished when, toward the close of Prof. N.'s treatise, I came upon the passage that begins as follows: "Should it really still be impossible, as some maintain, for one and the same consciousness to acknowledge both the practical and the theoretical, faith and knowledge," — it will be remembered that the Professor designates by these words positive religion and the human spirit's intellectual demand — "then in any case it would be the theoretical, and not the practical, that would have to be given up". How so? Then the matter is not settled and proved after all; it may still be possible that dualism cannot be carried through, that one must give up saying both yes and no? And I who thought that this view had — in the author's opinion — been utterly refuted as lacking the barest rudiments of dialectic and psychology (see p. 65). This sudden concession of the opposite's possibility has something very reassuring about it. The thing now is to change tactics: it is no longer dualism that is to be attacked, but the way out of it that it becomes our task to block. That way out is hinted at in various expressions in Prof. Nielsen and his adherents; the manoeuvre appears in various forms, but in reality it is easily recognised as one and the same.

In this passage it is said first and foremost that if one of the two sides is to be given up, [67] it must be the theoretical. One notices that the ship is in distress and can be saved only

by throwing its ballast overboard: if all it thereby quite reliably achieves is to capsize, its foundering is made tolerably evident. Regarded quite generally, the way out chosen here has something very comic about it. The whole doctrine consisted essentially in taking Kierkegaard's "Øieblikket" in one hand and Ørsted's "Aanden i Naturen" in the other, clapping them together and binding them into one. Now if someone comes forward with the objection that this joining or tying together will not really do, and if he is stubborn enough not to give way — very well! then the other party will not be the quarrelsome one, and cuts Ørsted away and keeps Kierkegaard. But what then remains of the whole doctrine which has been described, so foolishly, as the greatest merit of a man whose well-earned fame rests on quite other and far more genuinely scientific achievements? What does it then contain that has not been said far better, more richly and more fully by Kierkegaard?

If we now subject the matter to a closer examination: how does Prof. Nielsen prove the possibility of giving up the theoretical? "Existence," it runs, "is practical; a consciousness can exist without being theoretical, but a consciousness cannot be theoretical without existing. It is therefore possible to put existence highest and to keep theory." Is this sophism really becoming in a thinker, a thinker of Prof. Nielsen's rank? It is a play on words, a jesting toying with an ambiguous term. First the word "exist" is taken in the purely abstract sense of being at all, and then it is rightly said that a consciousness cannot be theoretical without existing; then it is taken in the peculiar sense just introduced, that of the life of the practical ideas, and now it is said of existence that it must of course be put highest. Alas, this "highest and lowest" is a precious designation to Prof. Nielsen: if the mutually contradictory utterances really could be reconciled, then it would surely be one and the same thing on which shelf I put them. If faith's superiority may not express itself in a reshaping of knowledge, it is not easy to grasp what it consists in. But so it stands: because one cannot theorise without existing, i.e. eating, drinking, sleeping etc., therefore the paradoxes of a positive faith must be set above the rational results of the human spirit. But never mind the weak grounding. Let us simply examine in and for itself whether the theoretical really can be given up. Now, if theory really were one with systematised science, and this in turn one with so and so many printed leaves bound in paper or leather, then it would be feasible to let science lie and let theory be theory. But if that is not how matters stand — if in the simplest conversation between a peasant and a fisherman, if in the plainest utterance of two simple thoughts that hang together and in whose sequence there is consistency — if, I say, in these quite straightforward [68] and everyday phenomena there is a germinating science, an elementary theory, what

then? No: science's essence depends neither on paper and printer's ink nor on system and completeness. Theory is present wherever a rational cognition takes place, be it ever so abrupt, ever so simple. Giving up theory, then, is not so easy a business.

Another form of the same train of thought occurs in Dr. Heegaard, op. cit. p. 447. The presentation there is designed to characterise the "will's concentration out beyond the rational" that is found in the believer in the paradox. It is so strong that under it all regard for theory disappears; "yes," we are told, "not even rational ethics at its maximum can come into consideration here". Good! So long as the individual does not have this concentration, he is only half a believer, and a half faith is no faith; but as soon as he has raised himself to faith's height, he has lost all theory entirely from view. What plainer statement of dualism's impossibility could one wish for than this, given by its own founder and set down on paper by one of its blindest defenders!

To this turn attaches another — imposing in Kierkegaard, but unfortunate here — that [70] the true believer has no time to occupy himself with scientific theory^{*)}. If this turn clears up nothing else, it shows at least that our theoreticians, like the old viking kings who, content with the honour, would readily give up their share of the booty, magnanimously renounce for their own persons the faith which, as generals, they so bravely win for everyone else.

I recall hearing Prof. Nielsen hint at yet another way out in his lectures; since I have no printed document to rely on, I touch on it of course with a certain reserve, though I do not doubt that Prof. N. will acknowledge having followed the train of thought that matters here. The Professor discussed the biblical passage where it is told that heaven opened and the spirit descended like a dove — the same passage that Mr. A. C. Larsen has cited in his book "Samvittighed og Videnskab" pag 59. The question was raised whether science might here bring its profane criticism to bear, and call the believer to account for how he manages to hold fast to a vault when he knows there is none, to believe that it opened, to take the dove for anything more than a pure symbol when he knows that the spirit cannot possibly shrink into a dove. That was the question, though [71] it was put in other words. The Professor then rebuked the spiritlessness that clung to the single image, that failed to understand that for faith these images were in flux and flow, in an incessant movement in which it was as impossible for criticism to seize them as for the understanding to grasp them. When one hears such a thing for the first time, one is ashamed of having been so spiritless; one feels like a chicaner put to shame. But on closer reflection it turns out here too that the standpoint can be maintained only

^{*)}See Heegaard p. 395, smlgn. Nielsen: *Evangelietroen og Theologien* p. 155.

when its distinctive character is given up and the strong tension between faith's and knowledge's ways of seeing is slackened. Just now we saw that one helped oneself by throwing theory aside; here it seems, conversely, to be faith that has to pay. For the clear historical reality that the believer must ascribe to the holy matters of fact, if he is not to find himself to his astonishment in agreement with the rationalist, seems here to give way to a mystical half-reality, an ideal reality that has nothing to say where the whole point is existence and fact.

But back to Prof. Nielsen's sacrifice, or possible sacrifice, of theory for the benefit of practical life. What is it, then, that is to be gained by it? One does not usually make even a merely possible sacrifice for nothing at all.

It is the will's originality and self-sufficiency that is to be secured; so far the sacrifice is intelligible enough. What is not intelligible is that anything much can be supposed to be won by it. For it must surely stand firm that the will in and for itself is quite as [72] immanent, quite as little supernatural an utterance of what is human as thought is. It is, after all, a view belonging to the naivety of a bygone age that certain of human life's and certain of earthly life's phenomena or utterances are more supernatural than the rest. It was on account of such a view that many an old believing Jew shook his head when the oil in the Copenhagen synagogue's eternal lamp was replaced by gas. For gas is a revolutionary element, highly natural, highly intellectual, and the light it spreads is strong and sharp; oil, by contrast, is a mild, thick-flowing liquid with an ancient title as the one right bringer of light, and is besides related to unction and all else of that kind. Is thought now to be determined in the same way as profane, while the will is given out as being akin to the positive? Is the will then faith, or the organ by which faith is grasped? So it is claimed, but the claim is utterly false. The will is not somehow half and half a transcendent and revealed power; it is purely human, purely rational. If faith's object is a miracle, then faith itself is just as fully a miracle^{*)}, and the will is no closer to the miracle than thought is. But on this point Prof. Nielsen makes himself guilty of a series of sleights of hand; and he who has so stubbornly combated the sophisms of speculative dogmatics puts forward a sophism perhaps less dazzling than theirs, but no less to be rejected. It [73] runs in the "Bemærkninger": "Should anyone, however, be so lively in the head and so light in his thoughts that it really makes him giddy to decide what is to stand highest and what lowest, faith or knowledge, and out of sheer liveliness confuses highest with lowest and lowest with highest, let him try to simplify matters by throwing away faith, the ideal of will, the principle of character, and living on pure theory: he will not escape

^{*)}Se "Philosophiske Smuler" pag. 95.

the doubling even so". What a pace! What strides, as though in seven-league boots! From existence to faith, from faith to the ideal of will and the principle of character! I am perhaps arrogating no excessive honour to myself in assuming that it is my humble self that is meant by the giddy lively one, and that the passage cited was called forth by a remark of mine in "Fædrelandet" of 16 February 1866. But if so, where have I spoken of throwing away first faith in general and then the ideal of will and the principle of character? As little as it is I who recommend the cure of amputating the head to save the life, so little do I wish any other mutilation of what is human, by which nothing is achieved but that the fever — in Holberg's phrase — leaves the patient. What else [74] have I tried to establish in my newspaper articles than that the union of two absolutely heterogeneous principles in the same consciousness is impossible? Where does it stand written that whoever gives up positive religion dissolves the religious itself into the scientific? A personality such as the American minister Theodore Parker is testimony enough to the looseness of that claim. And how will anyone convince us that the man who breaks with orthodoxy fails the ideal of will, that the man who wants to preserve character's unity in the theoretical and in the practical life is throwing away the principle of character? How will anyone establish that it is on this side that characterless ness is to be found, and on that side firmness? Here, as so often, the new doctrine must refer us to life and to what life teaches. What, then, does life teach, what answer does it give? Why, here, as always, the difficulty is that life teaches each man something different. But can anything be objected from the new doctrine's side when a man declares for his own part that he has found the truest characters and the purest will on the side where, according to the theory, the "intellectual amphibians" were to be found, and on the other hand the fluid spirits, vibrating with intellectual enthusiasm, precisely where according to the theory character's firmness was to be found? Of his own accord nobody would use so weak, so womanish an argument; but as far as I can see it is Prof. Nielsen himself who has licensed its use.

There frequently occur in the world of spirit phenomena of so decisive an importance that they have a claim on our interest, no matter whether they crop up at ever so great a [75] distance from us or in the midst of our own fatherland. There are others to which we would pay no attention had they arisen in China or in America or in Germany, but which we feel obliged to acknowledge or to contest for the sole reason that their nearness in time and space equips them with a power that their inner worth would never of itself confer on them. Prof. Nielsen's doctrine of the relation between religion and science belongs to the latter class. The reason we Danes ought to heed it is that it is Danish. And

yet — what am I saying, Danish! Is this unnatural doctrine, at odds with itself, Danish? It is so only in the literal sense of the word; in the deeper and truer sense it is very far indeed from being capable of being called Danish, so long as one credits Danish thinking with the qualities of soundness and clarity, so long as one agrees that the Danish cast of thought is not afraid of the dark, as the French so often is, but still less obscure, as the German so frequently is, and least of all shuns the light or defies the law. It is Danish, then, only in respect of its origin, and in so far as its coming into being is intelligible only from given historical presuppositions on Danish ground. This relation to the past has been invoked in order to assert the new doctrine's necessity, in order to present every opposition to it as an impotent attempt to hold back the age's own mighty wheel; but, busy as one was with feeling the pulse of world history, one has forgotten that the question here is not whether the theory is comprehensible as a natural offspring [76] of an earlier condition, or explicable as an escape from a double fire, but whether it is satisfactory, whether it is true, whether the pomp with which its adherents proclaim it is in any way justified. And one has failed to consider that every eclectic doctrine can with the same ease establish its genuine descent and its hereditary right to truth's throne.

Postscript: A piece by Prof. R. Nielsen that appeared after this book had gone to press, "Svar til Hr. Dr. phil. Pastor Zeuthen", gives me no occasion to add anything to what I have written or to correct it. For the most part it contains only a reprinting of the author's sallies against Martensen's Dogmatics.